

Price Watch

It's fresh prices for graphics cards this time. The latest chipsets from the AMD and NVIDIA stables covered

Killer Rigs

We tell you which components to go for if you want to build the perfect PC; be it budget, basic, mid-range or ultra-highend



Agent 001 goes GPU Hunting

Have a budget of ₹25,000, but don't know which card to get? Let Agent001 help you out

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His demeanor was menacing, I told him not to push that far, told him to stop right there, explained that overconfidence takes its toll on everything and everyone, but would he listen? Of course not! Then there was some smoke and the smell of something burning and I knew what it was and so did he. I looked at him and saw that he was in a stupor, he realised his mistake. Yup, my friend had accidentally burnt a particular component in his computer and not just any component but his old, yet faithful, GTX 275 graphics card while overclocking.

His parents took his case on this matter and this added to his misery, as they wouldn't listen to him, when he was trying to explain to them that no one at home can use the PC without a discrete graphics card as his motherboard did not have onboard graphics. He decided to purchase a new GPU, funded by himself of course, after what had happened. He wanted to go for something in the higher mid-range section as he could afford a budget of not more than 25k.

On the other hand, my nephew had his birthday coming up in a few days and I wanted to gift him something good. He's 12 and is into games. Racing games such as NFS, GRID and the likes are his territory. I decided to go for a mid-range GPU for him.

I was also contemplating getting a new graphics card as I intended to make

an HTPC/download rig from my old PC's components. So I had more than enough motivation to accompany my friend when he called me up for his quarterly trip to the Mumbai electronics haven.

Lamington Road was swarming with people as usual. We set ourselves in hyperdrive mode and went in a couple of shops to check out GPUs. Since the current crop of graphics cards from both AMD and NVIDIA have been in the market for quite some time, the prices we got were synonymous with most of the shops. I saw a familiar shop and we went in instantaneously. I asked for a GTX 660 Ti and for a Radeon HD 7870 for my friend and we saw a bunch of cards from ASUS, Palit and ZOTAC (for NVIDIA) and Sapphire, HIS and ASUS (for AMD). A regular GTX 660 Ti from ZOTAC was priced at ₹21,800 as well as a factory overclocked version – the ZOTAC GTX 660 Ti AMP! edition was around ₹24,000. We decided to get the **ZOTAC GTX 660 Ti** as my friend really didn't care for the small performance bump the overclocked version offered at the price and the performance difference between the HD 7870 and GTX 660 Ti, largely depended on games and hence was a subjective choice. His choice was finally made, and my glum-faced friend finally looked happy and at peace.

I still needed to buy two more cards, one for me and the other for my nephew. I knew for sure that the young lad will try to push stuff to its limits once I gave him

a GPU, so I decided to do a balancing act by going for a card which would not only run racing games easily but also other resource-heavy titles such as *FarCry 3* and *Crysis 3* at medium to high settings. The GPUs selected at the price were the GTX 650 Ti and the Radeon HD 7850. The shopkeeper showed us the MSI Radeon HD R7850 Power Edition 2GD5/OC and Palit GTX 650 Ti priced at ₹15,500 and ₹10,200 respectively. Other choice was the newer GTX 650 Ti BOOST from brands such as Galaxy, ASUS and ZOTAC. Cards from ASUS and ZOTAC were priced upwards of ₹13,000 while the 2 GB version of **Galaxy GTX 650 Ti Boost** costed ₹12,000 and we opted for that as the MSI Radeon HD 7850 was priced at a higher price.

Now remained a card for my incomplete HTPC and I knew that there were quite a lot of choices from AMD in the low-range price bracket. The AMD Radeon HD 7770 and HD 7750 were prime candidates, I settled upon the HD 7750 because of its price. The card I bought was the **ASUS Radeon HD 7750** at a decent bargained price of ₹7,500.

At the end of the entire ordeal, the shopkeeper somehow thought that me and my friend were big spenders and insisted on showing us the **Asus GTX TITAN**. He jubilantly quoted a whopping ₹67,500 for the card, looking at which me and my friend were quite dazed and we had to storm out of the shop as I was also getting late for my nephew's party. **4**